

MAULI
by Badrinarayan Pradhan (translated by Anmole Prasad)
RACHNA BOOKS
₹499; 185 pages

BOOKS

Bonds That Matter

Two women-centric books—***Mauli*** and ***The Woman Who Climbed Trees***—explore Nepali society and how women navigate it

Malati/ Mauli, Sangita, Elder-Mother, Dhankumari, and Radhika in Badrinarayan Pradhan's *Mauli*; Meena, Kaveri, Kumud, Sawari Devi, Preeti and other women in Smriti Ravindra's *The Woman Who Climbed Trees* share bonds that go well beyond the written word.

Although privileged to have studied in Darjeeling, Mauli has been alienated from her culture and learns about it from her extended family and father's employees in Jhapa and Ilam in Nepal. The border with India is fluid and people move freely, physically and culturally. Mauli is proud of her inheritance, but grows aware of its patriarchal and feudal restrictions. Buffeted by life's vagaries, Mauli comes into her own and faces the challenges head-on.

Meena, married to Manmohan at 14, leaves her home in Darbhanga for Sabaila and later Kathmandu. Meena navigates the complexities of marriage—to someone who does not even try to understand her—and motherhood, her identity as someone from the plains in a city dominated by people from the hills, her spirit that unravels as her constricted life takes its toll. In letting Meena's daughter Preeti tell her own story as well as parts of her mother's, Ravindra signals welcome albeit slow social change.

Female relationships are meaningful and crucial to the well-being of the women. Elder-mother and Mauli grow to love and respect each other. It is through Mauli's help that Sangita's political life emerges. "It was only with Sachi that I lost all my fears," Preeti states. Meena and her sister-in-law Kumud together face their demanding mother-in-law Sawari Devi, a widow hardened by patriarchy and the demands of a farm. Meena, Kirti and Shanti understand each other in ways only sisters can.

The women are hemmed in by inflexible gender roles. They devise ways to escape their confines, and this seems easier in the city than in rural settings. Meena, with her irreverence towards the deities whose images dot the streets of Kathmandu, takes her children to the cinema where she has to comfort and hush them with honey. She steals from Manmohan who does not deem it necessary for Meena to have her own money. Dhankumari, who works in the house, scoffs at the tradition of men dancing the Maruni dressed as women; encouraged by Mauli, she agrees to take part in the festivities and becomes "lost in the dance". Mauli laments that "there is no *mauka* [opportunity] in Nepal" for Dhankumari to become a great artiste.

The novels engage deeply with the political landscape. Pradhan's leftist orientation comes through in his showcasing of a feudal, casteist society. Both authors deal with the monarchy in Nepal and its opponents, many of whom lived in exile in India, artificial borders that separate people but can't prevent shared experiences. Ravindra weaves in myths and songs as she also explores the history of the Madhesis in Pahadi-dominated spaces. The books are welcome additions to a growing list of South Asian voices, especially of women and their allies. ■

Vineeta Rai

THE WOMAN WHO CLIMBED TREES
by Smriti Ravindra
HARPERCOLLINS
₹599; 432 pages

